Real Leadership

Book Positioning Research Report

Prepared for Jason B. Horne, Ed.D., MBA, SFO • April 18, 2026

Executive Summary

This report maps where a proposed book titled Real Leadership, arguing that U.S. school leadership has devolved into compliance-based management, would fit into the existing canon of educational leadership literature. Findings come from six parallel research agents covering the foundational canon, the accountability critique tradition, the moral and adaptive leadership strands, the practitioner trade market, the publisher landscape, and the Tennessee compliance context.

Bottom line. A clear whitespace exists. The academic literature on managerialism and performativity (Mehta, Ball, Anderson, Hargreaves, Dolan) provides intellectual scaffolding but does not reach practicing leaders. The practitioner trade shelf (Whitaker, Casas, Kafele, Fullan, Bambrick-Santoyo) has the audience but rarely names compliance as the structural problem. The closest direct competitors are Frederick Hess's Cage-Busting Leadership (2013), Jal Mehta's The Allure of Order (2013), and Jimmy Casas's Live Your Excellence (2020), and none of the three combine: (1) a frontal thesis that leadership has been operationally replaced by compliance officering, (2) a current practitioner voice from inside a district leadership seat, (3) a state-grounded empirical base (TISA, TEAM, A–F, TVAAS, RBM provide unusually clean instrumentation in Tennessee), (4) a small-city Southern perspective, and (5) a data-science and MBA analytical lens. That five-way combination is the defensible position.

Recommended positioning.

- Primary frame: The Ledger vs The Hallway. Leaders live in two worlds; the ledger (reports, rubrics, dashboards, audits) has expanded to crowd out the hallway (teachers, students, families). Real Leadership is measured in hallway minutes.
- Secondary frame: Chief or Compliance Officer? A Tuesday-by-Tuesday look at what the job title promises vs. what the calendar actually holds.
- Publisher priorities: Corwin and Routledge Eye on Education are the highest-fit traditional targets; Harvard Education Press is credible if framed with evidence rigor; Times 10 Publications (Hack Learning) is a strong plan B; Solution Tree is a structural mismatch; Jossey-Bass likely requires an agent.

- Platform gaps to close before pitching: launch a weekly newsletter or podcast, land one Educational Leadership or Ed Week byline, confirm one non-ASBO national conference session.

1. The Question and Why It Matters

Wallace Foundation synthesis research, SAM time-use data, and RAND's State of the American Principal reports converge on a stark finding: today's principals devote roughly 23 percent of their week to instructional leadership and up to 75 percent to management and regulatory duties. National principal turnover spiked to roughly 16 percent after the pandemic and is still elevated. The gap between what the profession says leaders should do and what the calendar actually holds has widened substantially across the NCLB-to-ESSA decade, and compliance demands in Tennessee have only thickened with TISA (2022), A–F letter grades (first issued 2023), and post-Covenant School safety mandates.

The proposed book argues that "leadership" is still the word on the org chart, but the job has been operationally replaced by something closer to compliance officering. That argument has precedents in the scholarly literature but has not been written as a trade book for practicing principals and superintendents in the current (post-ESSA, post-pandemic, post-ESSER) moment.

2. The Canon Map: Where the Book Would Sit

The U.S. educational leadership canon splits into three broad camps. A book arguing "real leadership vs. compliance leadership" must position against each.

- The moral/community school (Sergiovanni, late Fullan, Hargreaves, Starratt) — explicitly anti-compliance, pro-values; natural allies.
- The research-synthesis school (Leithwood, Marzano, Hattie, Hallinger, Murphy) — measurement-oriented; their instruments became evaluation rubrics; the book must engage this tradition critically without dismissing the evidence base.
- The practitioner-movement school (DuFour, Bambrick-Santoyo, Balanced Leadership) — structurally compliance-adjacent through PLC protocols; the book must distinguish original intent from compliance-ified enactment.

Canon Positioning Table

Author / Work	Year	Compliance Stance	Positioning for Real Leadership
Sergiovanni — Moral Leadership; Lifeworld of Leadership	1992/2000	Hostile (systemsworld colonizes lifeworld)	Ancestor. Build on.
Fullan — Leading in a Culture of Change; Coherence; Nuance	2001–2019	Skeptical ("wrong drivers")	Build on late Fullan; differentiate.
Leithwood et al. — How Leadership Influences Student Learning	2004	Neutral (motivation work skeptical)	Beside — evidence base.
Marzano, Waters, McNulty — School Leadership That Works	2005	Pro implicitly (21 responsibilities became eval	Against. Name as compliance infrastructure.

		rubrics)	
DuFour et al. — Learning by Doing; In Praise of American Educators	2006–2015	Mixed (original pro-professional; impl = compliance)	Beside. Reframe original intent.
Hattie — Visible Learning series	2008–2020	Ambivalent (misuse = compliance scientism)	Against the misuse, beside evidence.
Murphy — ISLLC / PSEL standards	1996–2015	Pro (he built them)	Respectful opposition.
Hallinger — PIMRS instructional leadership	1982–present	Pro via measurement	Against instrument logic.
Hargreaves & Fullan — Professional Capital	2012	Hostile to business capital	Build on (natural ally).
Darling-Hammond — The Flat World and Education	2010	Explicit critique (accountability dumbs down)	Build on (equity scaffolding).

3. The Compliance Critique Tradition

The critique of accountability-driven compliance culture is a forty-year intellectual tradition with uneven focus. Most canonical works target one of three objects: policy architects and reform movements; teachers and the deprofessionalization of teaching; or the technocratic instruments of reform (tests, standards, metrics). Very few take principal and superintendent behavior as the object of critique, and almost no widely read trade book argues specifically that school leaders have collapsed into compliance officers. That is the opening.

Closest Intellectual Ancestors

- Jal Mehta — The Allure of Order (Oxford, 2013). The most important scholarly frame. Traces three waves of reformers imposing "rational administration from above" on a field whose practice is irreducibly complex. Killer line: "We have been trying to solve a problem of professional practice by bureaucratic means." Unit of analysis is policy history and teaching, not leader behavior. Leaves leadership-role critique unwritten.
- Frederick Hess — Cage-Busting Leadership (Harvard Education Press, 2013). The single most direct precedent. Argues leaders have more freedom than they think and should stop hiding behind regulations. Frames cage as largely self-imposed — reads as blaming leaders. AEI/reform-right flavor limits appeal to traditional K–12 audience. Pre-pandemic, pre-AI, pre-politicization wave.
- Gary Anderson — Advocacy Leadership: Toward a Post-Reform Agenda in Education (Routledge, 2009). Direct argument that managerial leader roles are counterproductive. Academic press; urban equity framing; predates TISA-era compliance stack.
- Chris Dolan — Paradox and the School Leader (Springer, 2020). Fifteen paradoxes between managerial demands and professional identity. Australian context, academic price, invisible to U.S. practitioners.
- Stephen J. Ball — The Teacher's Soul and the Terrors of Performativity (2003) and surrounding corpus. The foundational vocabulary for the critique. UK higher-ed and secondary frame; not integrated for U.S. K–12 leaders.

- Catherine Voulgarides — Beyond Compliance: Reclaiming Agency in Special Education (Harvard Education Press, 2025). Direct title hit but scoped to IDEA and racial disproportionality, not the whole leadership role.

Related Classics

- Diane Ravitch — The Death and Life of the Great American School System (2010), Reign of Error (2013), Slaying Goliath (2020). Policy architects; leaders largely absent.
- Linda Darling-Hammond — The Flat World and Education (2010). Distinguishes test-based from professional accountability; teacher-preparation focus.
- Daniel Koretz — The Testing Charade (2017). Test-centric regime; Campbell's Law; leaders off-stage.
- Richard Elmore — School Reform from the Inside Out (2004). The line "accountability without capacity." Closest of the academics to a leader-behavior argument, but dense and aimed at researchers.
- Deborah Meier — The Power of Their Ideas (1995), In Schools We Trust (2002). A principal's voice, but pre-NCLB maturity.
- Anthony Bryk & Barbara Schneider — Trust in Schools (2002). Principal behavior as relational infrastructure; frames trust-building, not compliance-fighting.

4. Adjacent Leadership Strands (Moral, Authentic, Servant, Adaptive)

Several parallel traditions circle the same territory without naming compliance as the adversary. Understanding where each stops is useful for positioning.

- Moral / ethical (Starratt, Beck, Sergiovanni, Shapiro & Stefkovich, Branson). Virtue-ethics vocabulary; heavy in doctoral programs; rarely on a working principal's nightstand.
- Human side of change (Robert Evans, The Human Side of School Change, 1996). Rational resistance, identity and loss, authenticity as precondition. Pre-NCLB but diagnosis maps cleanly onto the compliance era.
- Servant (Greenleaf, Spears). Dispositional; popular in faith-based and independent schools; uneven in public districts.
- Adaptive (Heifetz & Linsky; Heifetz, Grashow, Linsky 2009). Technical vs adaptive distinction is the most usable vocabulary for translating the compliance critique; not education-specific.
- Trade crossover read by practitioners: Brené Brown (Dare to Lead, 2018) — closest on vocabulary of vulnerability and courage; Jim Collins (Good to Great and the Social Sectors, 2005); Patrick Lencioni (The Advantage, 2012); Simon Sinek (Start With Why, Leaders Eat Last). None engage compliance architecture.
- Formation (Parker Palmer, Margaret Wheatley). Contemplative registers; teacher-focused or pre-NCLB.

The academic literature is actively theorizing the compliance-moral purpose tension in 2024–2025 (Ylimaki et al. in BJES on moral purpose in performative times; Heys on the accountability

paradigm post-NCLB in Educational Policy; Torres, Waldron & Burns on compliance, chaos, or coherence in AERA Open; Uzzell et al. on equity pursuit under ESSA in EAQ; the "very small cog in the wheel" study of principal perceptions post-ESSA). There is a live scholarly conversation with no trade-book translator yet.

5. The Competitive Trade-Book Landscape

Todd Whitaker is the unambiguous commercial volume leader. What Great Teachers Do Differently has sold over 750,000 U.S. copies with eight translations; What Great Principals Do Differently is in its third edition (Routledge/Eye on Education, 2020). Whitaker's thesis across the series is simple, inspirational, listicle-structured, and silent-to-skeptical on compliance — that stylistic restraint is exactly why the books sell safely at every level.

The most interesting current neighbor is Jimmy Casas. In Live Your Excellence (ConnectEDD, 2020) he explicitly argues for shifting schools "away from a culture that runs on compliance, blame, and fear to a culture based on investment and caring." That is almost word-for-word the Real Leadership thesis — but Casas frames it as a teacher/adult-culture argument, silent on budgets, HR, audits, bureaucracy, state-level mandates, and the operational-administration work.

Christopher Tienken's Cracking the Code of Education Reform: Creative Compliance and Ethical Leadership (Corwin, 2019) is the closest direct intellectual neighbor; Tienken co-edited the AASA Decennial Study. Scholarly register; modest sales; does not make the full "role has been hollowed out" case.

Competitive Landscape (Selected Titles)

Author / Book	Thesis (≈)	Compliance Stance	Gap vs. Real Leadership
Whitaker — What Great Principals Do Differently (2020)	Great principals focus on people, set tone by example, stay positive	Silent	No structural critique; no scholar voice
Kafele — The Principal 50 series (ASCD)	Reflective questions reveal whether you are really leading	Silent, equity-tilted	No ops lane; no compliance structural argument
Casas — Live Your Excellence / Culturize	Shift from compliance/blame/fear to investment/caring	Overtly anti-compliance at culture level	Frames compliance only as adult culture; silent on ops, finance, mandates
Couros — The Innovator's Mindset	Compliance kills innovation	Anti-compliance at pedagogy level	Pedagogical, not administrative
Fullan — The Principal 2.0 / Nuance	Loosen accountability; build capacity; nuance over quick fixes	Explicitly skeptical of accountability	Closest in stance but abstract; not from inside an ops chair
Hess — Cage-Busting Leadership	Leaders have more freedom than they think	Pro-accountability, anti-excuse	Opposite polarity: blames leaders rather than the regime
Levenson — Smarter Budgets, Smarter Schools (HEP 2025)	Ops choices drive outcomes more than curriculum	Pro-evidence, silent on compliance	Owns ops lane but no identity/role critique

		critique	
Tienken — Cracking the Code of Education Reform	Leaders should critique reforms; use creative compliance	Strongly skeptical	Scholar voice, academic register
Starr — Equity-Based Leadership (HEP 2022)	Equity lens plus complexity management transforms districts	Skeptical of narrow accountability	Equity frame; not compliance-role thesis
Muhammad — Transforming School Culture; The Way Forward (2024)	Four teacher types; leaders must overcome staff division	Silent	PLC frame, not compliance/role critique
Safir & Dugan — Street Data (Corwin 2021)	Replace big-data accountability with street-level data	Explicitly skeptical	Equity/data frame rather than role-hollowing thesis

6. Publisher Landscape and Market Signals

Jason's credential stack (sitting Asst. Director of Schools, Ed.D., MBA, SFO, ETSU adjunct, ASBO Advisory Committee seat, nine dissertation committees, upcoming ASBO webinar and Elizabethton keynote) is sufficient for Corwin, Routledge Eye on Education, and Times 10 to take a cold proposal seriously. ASCD, Harvard Education Press, and Jossey-Bass will want stronger public platform (newsletter or podcast with measurable audience, at least one magazine byline, one non-ASBO national conference session).

Publisher Fit Matrix

Publisher	Fit	Why	How to Approach
Corwin (SAGE)	High	Publishes reformist practitioner titles; first-time-author friendly; PD pipeline amplifies reach; Street Data is a direct analogue	content.submissions@corwin.com with proposal + 2 chapters. Emphasize PD-speaking.
Routledge Eye on Education	High	Practitioner K–12 imprint; Heather Jarrow actively acquires leadership books	Submit via Routledge portal; emphasize research base + TN district case.
Times 10 Publications	High	Anti-status-quo practical hacks; lean publisher; first-time-author terms	Reframe as "Hacking Compliance" or 10-move structure. Contact Mark Barnes.
Harvard Education Press	Med-High	Leadership is a named strength; Karen Adler acquires the lane	Email Karen Adler. Lead with evidence base and policy implications.
ASCD (ISTE+ASCD)	Medium	Strong brand match for reader; platform-weighted acquisitions	Consider ASCD Arias (~10k words) as foot-in-the-door. acquisitions@ascd.org.
Teachers College Press	Medium	Reformist-leaning academic press; Brian Ellerbeck edits leadership/policy	Build book around data/research with practitioner color.
Jossey-Bass (Wiley)	Low-Med	Declining K–12 list; needs agent and trade polish	Skip unless agented.
Solution Tree	Low	Business model sells compliance frameworks; structural conflict	Don't pitch unless pivoted to "authentic PLC" framing.
Greenleaf / Lioncrest (hybrid)	Medium	Retain IP and higher royalties; $25–50k out of pocket	Only if paired with speaking/consulting business plan.
Self-publish (KDP)	Low now	Works with pre-built audience (Bauer model); platform not there yet	Viable plan C after 12–18 months of platform-building.

Market Signals (Directional)

- Conference keynote tone 2024–26 is equity-forward, pro-student-voice, AI/change-management. No current anchor keynote voice is the "compliance is killing leadership" argument — open territory.
- Amazon perennial top titles in Education Administration include Whitaker's What Great Principals Do Differently; Casas's Culturize; Safir & Dugan's Street Data; Kafele's Principal 50; Marshall's Rethinking Teacher Supervision and Evaluation; Embracing MESSY Leadership; Bauer's Better Leaders Better Schools Roadmap.
- The loudest LinkedIn/X voices shaping the practicing-principal conversation include Daniel Bauer, Peter DeWitt, Eric Sheninger, Shane Safir, Jimmy Casas, Baruti Kafele, Robyn R. Jackson, Kim Marshall. All have a podcast, newsletter, or Ed Week column.

7. Positioning Recommendation

The Gap, Named

A trade-length, practitioner-voiced, state-grounded book that names the compliance-officer substitution at the center of the principalship and superintendency, written from a current seat inside a rural or small-city district, and equipped with the quantitative vocabulary (time-use, throughput, constraint) to show the substitution rather than just assert it.

The academic literature (Ball, Anderson, Dolan, Mehta, Niesche) has the theory. The practitioner literature (Fullan, DuFour, Marzano, Bambrick) has the audience but not the critique. Wallace Foundation and RAND have the numbers but not the narrative. No one has combined them.

Working Thesis (Draft)

School leadership in America has been quietly replaced by school compliance management. We still call principals and superintendents "leaders" because the word is on the org chart, but the actual job is a stack of reporting obligations, evaluative rubrics, audit trails, and state and federal submissions that now consume three out of every four hours on the calendar. Real Leadership names the substitution, measures it in Tennessee where the instrumentation is clearest, and argues the way back is not a new framework or a new book of sayings but a deliberate re-allocation of the leader's week toward the small number of acts that actually move a system.

Three Candidate Frames

- The Stack. Compliance is not a burden, it is a stack — layered systems (TISA, TEAM, TVAAS, Title I–IV, IDEA, CRDC, audits, safety plans) that compound. Each layer is individually defensible; the sum is the problem. Systems-engineering frame; uniquely suited to the data-science voice.
- The Ledger vs the Hallway. The ledger (reports, rubrics, dashboards, audits) has expanded to fill the week; the hallway (teachers, students, families, teams) has shrunk. Real Leadership is

measured in hallway minutes. Simple, visual, memorable, testable. Probably the single best trade-book frame.

- Chief or Compliance Officer? The job title says Chief — Director of Schools, Superintendent, Principal. The job reality is Compliance Officer. The book walks through what a real chief does (sets direction, allocates resources, protects people, takes risk, tells the truth) vs. what a compliance officer does (documents, submits, verifies, reports, audits). Direct and confrontational.

Three Chapter Arc Options

Arc A — Diagnosis / Instrumentation / Recovery:

- The substitution (thesis)
- Inventory of the stack (Tennessee as case)
- Hours on the calendar (time-use evidence)
- The instruments that crowd out judgment (TEAM, TVAAS, A–F)
- The audit trail as shadow job description
- The adjunct's mirror (what we teach aspiring leaders)
- A budget for leadership (reallocating the week)
- Five acts that actually move a system
- What a district built for leadership instead of compliance looks like
- Real leadership, finally defined

Arc B — One day, one year, one career:

Narrative structure following Jason through a day, a year, and a career, with the compliance stack visible at every layer. More accessible and trade-readable. Weaker analytically but stronger on sales.

Arc C — The Ten Decisions:

Each chapter takes one concrete leadership decision (hiring a principal, setting a budget, handling a safety incident, responding to an A-grade drop, answering an audit finding) and shows the compliance move vs. the leadership move with a scorecard. Highly reusable as a workshop and training text.

8. Bottom Line and Next Steps

There is a real and defensible gap for Real Leadership. Jason's unique combination (sitting district administrator running the operational stack, ETSU adjunct, MBA, data-science trajectory, SFO, small-city Southern vantage) is not duplicated on the current shelf. The closest competitors (Hess 2013, Mehta 2013, Casas 2020) each step up to the thesis and turn away. No existing book makes the argument from inside a current central-office seat with the instrumentation to prove it.

Recommended next steps:

- Draft a 2-page book proposal summary: thesis, table of contents, competing titles, market, author platform. Start with the Ledger vs Hallway frame unless iteration surfaces a stronger metaphor.
- Write the sample chapter first. Suggest: "Hours on the Calendar" (time-use chapter) — it leverages the data-science voice, establishes the empirical spine, and is the single most persuasive piece of evidence for the thesis.
- Begin platform-building: weekly LinkedIn newsletter on the Real Leadership thesis (target 2,000 subscribers by month 6); pitch one Educational Leadership magazine article; submit one Ed Week Opinion piece.
- Propose one AASA, NAESP, or ASCD national session for the 2027 cycle (AASA NCE 2027 call opens summer 2026).
- First outreach: Heather Jarrow at Routledge Eye on Education and Corwin's acquisitions team. These are the most receptive cold-proposal targets. HEP's Karen Adler is the prestige play if the proposal can be framed with heavy evidence.

Open question: is there appetite to co-author with a recognizable voice (e.g., a current sitting superintendent with a national profile) to accelerate platform? Likely worth exploring only if the lead voice remains Jason's.

Appendix A: The Tennessee Compliance Stack

Inventory of the compliance domains that Tennessee principals and central-office administrators live inside simultaneously. Each domain is individually defensible; the sum is the argument.

Compliance Domain	Authority	Cadence	Time Cost
TISA Accountability Report (3rd-grade ELA goal, gap-closure, budget narrative)	T.C.A. §49-3-112; TDOE; TPRB	Annual, Nov. 1	Moderate, rolling
TISA student-generator data (11 weighted categories)	TDOE TISA office	Continuous; ADM twice yearly	Heavy (data integrity)
TEAM principal evaluation (TILS, 4 obs, TNCompass)	SBE 5.201	Annual cycle	High
TEAM teacher evaluation (administered by principal)	SBE 5.201	Annual, ongoing	Very high
TCAP / TNReady administration	TDOE Assessment	Spring annually; EOC fall/spring	Heavy in windows
School letter grades (A–F)	T.C.A. §49-1-228	Annual release (Dec)	Reputational tax
TVAAS (35% of evaluation, historically)	SAS/TDOE	Annual	Moderate
ESSA accountability (CSI/TSI/ATSI, per-pupil reporting)	ED.gov; TDOE Federal Programs	Continuous; annual plan cycles	Heavy for identified schools
Best for All / district improvement plans	TDOE Best for All	3-year + annual	Episodic, large
IDEA / Special Education (FAPE, 60-day eval, IEPs, Indicators 1–17)	IDEA Part B; 0520-01-09	Continuous + annual	Very heavy; legal risk
Results-Based Monitoring (on-site, virtual, online)	TDOE Federal Programs	Annual risk scoring	Spikes
Title I-A (needs assessment, set-asides, comparability, SNS)	ESEA; TDOE	Annual ePlan	Heavy, auditable
Title II-A (PD plans, equity plans)	ESEA Title II	Annual	Moderate
Title III (EL identification, ELPA21, parent notifications)	ESEA Title III; TDOE	Continuous	Moderate–Heavy
Title IV-A (well-rounded, safe schools, ed-tech)	ESEA Title IV	Annual	Light–Moderate
ESSER III closeout (late liquidation through Mar 30, 2026)	USED	Closeout phase	Time-bound
Finance / audit (GASB 34, SBITA GASB 96, internal funds, single audit)	TN Comptroller	Annual	Heavy; material-weakness risk
State Board governance (7 hours training annually; 21 hours new members)	SBE Rule 0520-01-02-.11	Annual	Governance
School safety (annual plan, threat assessment, SRO, drills)	2023 Public Chapter; TDOE	Annual	Heavy post-Covenant
Attendance (chronic absenteeism indicator)	T.C.A. 49-6-3000 series	Continuous	Moderate
Discipline (suspensions, disproportionality, restraint/isolation)	TDOE; IDEA	Continuous	Moderate, rising
Nutrition (USDA NSLP/SBP, Admin Review triennial, Professional Standards)	USDA FNS; TDOE SNP	Cyclical + continuous	Heavy at AR year
Licensure / PD (60 PDPs per cycle; TLSA foundational literacy)	TDOE Educator Licensure	6-year renewal	Moderate
Civil Rights Data Collection (~2,000 elements)	OCR, USED	Biennial	Heavy in collection year
Section 504 (identification, plans, discipline manifestation)	OCR	Continuous	Moderate, legal risk
FERPA / student data privacy (DPAs, directory opt-outs, ed-tech)	FERPA; TN SOPIPA	Continuous	Moderate, rising

Combined with Wallace Foundation / SAM time-use research (principals spend ~23% of their week on instructional leadership; up to 75% on management; 84% of elementary principals report 60+ hour weeks) and RAND's 2022 State of the American Principal (COVID increased crisis-management time by ~45%), the stack is the empirical foundation for the book's central claim.

References

Deduplicated, alphabetized list of the core sources informing this positioning report. Full per-agent source lists (approximately 180 entries across six agents) preserved in research_run_log.md.

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